ILLINOIS

The Prairie State



Chicago in the summer of 1893 was a city performing miracles. Along the lakefront, the World's Columbian Exposition had transformed a stretch of muddy shoreline into the gleaming "White City," drawing more than 27 million visitors from around the world to marvel at electric lights, moving sidewalks, and the first Ferris wheel ever built. The city was loud, ambitious, and hungry—in every sense of the word.

It was against this backdrop that the humble hot dog found its footing in Chicago. Vendors worked the crowds of the Exposition with steamed sausages tucked into bread, cheap and filling and fast. The sausage itself had roots in the German and Austrian immigrant communities that had poured into Chicago throughout the mid-1800s, settling in neighborhoods on the North and South Sides and bringing with them a tradition of finely seasoned beef and pork encased and cured. Chicago's Union Stock Yards, which had opened in 1865 and made the city the undisputed meatpacking capital of the world, meant that quality beef was never far from anyone's hand—or anyone's cart.

But it was the Great Depression that truly made the Chicago Dog what it is. In 1929, Abe "Fluky" Drexler set up a Depression-era stand at the corner of Maxwell and Halsted Streets on Chicago's Near West Side, in the heart of a densely packed immigrant neighborhood where Eastern European Jews, Italians, and Greeks lived practically on top of one another. Maxwell Street was already legendary—a sprawling open-air market where vendors sold everything from shoes to furniture from pushcarts and blankets spread on the ground. Drexler sold his hot dogs for a nickel, and to justify the price and stretch the value for hungry, cash-strapped customers, he piled them high. Yellow mustard, bright green relish, fresh chopped onion, a slice of tomato, a kosher dill pickle spear, sport peppers, and a dash of celery salt—all of it loaded onto an all-beef frankfurter nestled in a poppy seed bun and never, under any circumstances, touched by ketchup.

That last point was not accidental. Local lore says ketchup—sweet, vinegary, and containing sugar—had no place alongside a proper beef sausage. What Drexler built instead was a riot of contrasting flavors that somehow achieved perfect balance: the bite of mustard, the brightness of tomato, the pucker of pickle, the heat of sport pepper, the grassy snap of relish, and the quiet authority of celery salt tying it all together. Locals called it being "dragged through the garden," and the name stuck because it was exactly right.

The Chicago Dog spread outward from Maxwell Street the way all great street food does—through appetite and word of mouth, neighborhood by neighborhood, stand by stand. By the mid-20th century, it had crossed every boundary the city had—ethnic, economic, geographic—becoming the rare food that North Siders and South Siders, Cubs fans and White Sox fans, could agree on without argument. Fluky's eventually moved to a proper restaurant, and dozens of stands and restaurants followed the template faithfully, because in Chicago, deviation from the formula is not considered creativity. It is considered a mistake.

What makes this dish so exciting to recreate is how deceptively simple it is—and how unforgiving. Every topping earns its place. Every layer adds something the others cannot. Assemble it with care, respect the order, hold the ketchup, and you will understand in one bite why this city has never needed to change a thing.

CHICAGO DOG

Not just a hot dog but a Depression-era act of defiance—and one of the most satisfying things you will ever eat standing up.

Yield: 1 hot dog

INGREDIENTS

- 1 poppy seed hot dog bun
- 1 all-beef hot dog (Vienna Beef preferred)
- 1 tsp yellow mustard
- 1 Tbsp sweet green relish (neon green preferred)
- 1 Tbsp chopped onions
- ¼ tomato, sliced
- 1 dill pickle spear
- 2–3 sport peppers
- Celery salt, to taste

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Steam the bun*: Steam the bun until warm and soft (or wrap it in a damp paper towel and microwave for 10 seconds if needed).
2. *Heat the dog*: Steam or grill the hot dog until heated through.
3. *Assemble*: Place the hot dog in the steamed poppy seed bun, then add the toppings in this order: yellow mustard, sweet relish, chopped onions, tomato slices (on one side), a dill pickle spear (on the other side), sport peppers, and a dash of celery salt.

NOTES & TIPS

- Never add ketchup—that's a true Chicago rule.
- Don't forget to multiply the ingredients as needed for extra servings.

